

August 20, 2026

Ambetter from Absolute Total Care
Provider Appeals Department

RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — Morgan Gislason (MRN MUSC1901974), Claim MUSC-9AF8-3

Patient	Morgan Gislason (DOB 2007-12-15)
MRN	MUSC1901974
Member ID / Group	AMB513828945 / GRP-47184
Claim number	MUSC-9AF8-3
Date of service	2026-04-29
Procedure billed	CPT 99214 — Office/outpatient visit, established patient, moderate complexity
Primary diagnosis	J06.9 — Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified
Denied amount	\$406.79
Denial code	CARC 50 / RARC N115 — These are non-covered services because this is not deemed a 'medical necessity' by the payer.
Appeal deadline	2026-09-12

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

SUMMARY OF APPEAL

MUSC Health is submitting this formal appeal on behalf of patient Morgan Gislason (MRN: MUSC1901974, Member ID: AMB513828945) regarding the denial of Claim MUSC-9AF8-3 for services rendered on April 29, 2026, at MUSC Health Rutledge Tower Ambulatory Care. The claim was denied on June 14, 2026, under CARC 50 ("These are non-covered services because this is not deemed a 'medical necessity' by the payer") with RARC N115, citing a Local Coverage Determination. The payer's accompanying remark stated that "documentation submitted does not establish that the service was reasonable and necessary for the diagnosis reported." MUSC Health respectfully disagrees with this determination and requests full reversal and payment of the allowed amount of \$216.39.

CLINICAL BACKGROUND

Morgan Gislason is an 18-year-old established female patient with a documented history of recurrent upper respiratory conditions, including prior episodes of viral sinusitis, acute viral pharyngitis, and streptococcal sore throat, as well as active perennial allergic rhinitis managed with fexofenadine hydrochloride, which has been an ongoing medication since 2008. Her allergic history is further supported by a prior allergy screening evaluation and a course of subcutaneous immunotherapy completed in 2021. On April 29, 2026, Ms. Gislason presented to Dr. James H. Ferrell, MD (NPI 1992837465) at an on-campus outpatient hospital facility for an established patient visit. The encounter was coded as CPT 99214, reflecting a moderate-complexity office visit, with a primary diagnosis of J06.9 (Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified) and a secondary diagnosis of R69.

BASIS FOR APPEAL

CPT code 99214 represents an established patient office or outpatient visit of moderate medical decision-making complexity, and its assignment is consistent with the clinical picture presented. Ms. Gislason's active perennial allergic rhinitis creates a documented predisposition to upper respiratory infections and complicates the clinical management of acute upper respiratory illness, supporting the level of complexity reflected in the selected evaluation and management code. The rendering physician, a credentialed provider within the Ambetter from Absolute Total Care network, exercised professional clinical judgment in determining that an in-person evaluation was warranted and that the complexity of the encounter met the threshold for a 99214.

The payer's denial rests on the assertion that the documentation does not establish medical necessity for the diagnosis reported. However, an acute upper respiratory infection in a patient with active, medication-dependent perennial allergic rhinitis is a clinically recognized scenario requiring physician evaluation to differentiate between allergic exacerbation, viral illness, and potential bacterial superinfection — all of which carry distinct management pathways. The evaluation and management of such a presentation by a physician in an outpatient setting is consistent with generally accepted standards of care. The denial does not identify any specific documentation deficiency, nor does it articulate which element of the LCD was not satisfied, making it impossible to address a targeted clinical gap. MUSC Health requests that Ambetter provide the specific LCD upon which this determination was based, along with the precise criteria that were found unmet, so that any additional documentation may be supplied promptly.

REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health respectfully requests that Ambetter from Absolute Total Care overturn the denial of Claim MUSC-9AF8-3 and reprocess the claim for payment at the contracted allowed amount of \$216.39. Should the reviewer require additional clinical documentation from the April 29, 2026 encounter, including the physician's notes, problem list, or medication reconciliation, MUSC Health will provide those records immediately upon request through the secure provider portal. This appeal is being submitted in advance of the September 12, 2026 deadline for reconsideration and formal appeal.

Respectfully submitted,

Angela R. Whitfield, RN, BSN, CPC

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Enclosures

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record